



YOU DON'T KNOW ME, BUT I KNOW YOU

THE LIVES OF OTHERS / 2006

IN CONTEXT

GENRE
Drama

DIRECTOR
**Florian Henckel
von Donnersmarck**

WRITER
**Florian Henckel
von Donnersmarck**

STARS
**Ulrich Mühe, Martina
Gedeck, Sebastian Koch,
Ulrich Tukur**

BEFORE
1989 Ulrich Mühe stars in *Spider's Web*, West Germany's last submission to the Academy Awards before the country's dissolution in 1990.

2003 Wolfgang Becker's *Good Bye Lenin!* is a comedy about the reunification of Germany.

AFTER
2008 *The Baader Meinhof Complex* tells the story of far-left West German militant group the Red Army Faction.

The *Lives of Others* was inspired by an image formed in the mind of German director Florian Henckel von Donnersmarck. He pictured a secret policeman, inert and gray-faced, headphones clamped to his ears, listening in on the lives of others because it was his duty to "know everything." Was it really possible, Donnersmarck wondered, that this policeman could remain unsentimental about the private lives under his surveillance?

Set in East Berlin in 1983, this powerful movie offers a glimpse into the workings of the Stasi, the secret police of East

Germany's Communist regime. It was one of the first serious attempts to capture the day-to-day hell of the East German state, in which people attempted to live normal lives without the right to privacy or individual thought.

The listener in the attic

The story centers around a model Stasi officer, Gerd Wiesler (Ulrich Mühe), who is given the routine job of finding incriminating material on a playwright, Georg Dreyman (Sebastian Koch), by spying on him and his lover, the famous actress Christa-Maria Sieland (Martina Gedeck). Installed in the roof of the

Modern German cinema

After the acclaim that greeted the New German Cinema of the 1970s, German movies of recent years have tended to concern themselves with the past. There have, of course, been exceptions, but the most highly regarded German movies of this century have been fascinated by the country's modern history. *The Counterfeiters* looked back to World War II, as did *Downfall*. The terrorism of the 1970s was

the subject of *The Baader Meinhof Complex* (2008), while *The Lives of Others* and *Good Bye Lenin!* offered audiences a human take on the dissolution of East Germany.

Key movies

2003 *Good Bye Lenin!*
2004 *Downfall*
2006 *The Lives of Others*
2007 *The Counterfeiters*